

Top Research Compliance Challenges Universities Face Today & Practical Ways to Address Them

For VPs of Compliance and Principal Investigators

Operational Compliance Challenges

Regulatory burdens in university research compliance aren't about inconsistent regulations; they are about operational challenges. Compliance departments are under pressure from the growing volume of research, the number of independent investigators, complicated data systems, shifting and overlapping regulations, and under-resourced and disjointed systems.

Organizations in the regulated sectors that rely on manual or partially digital systems experience high levels of documentation mistakes, slower response times, and inconsistent compliance.¹ Even in situations where operating procedures are clear, these issues remain.

✚ **Key Data:** The volume of research in universities is closely aligned with those in the healthcare systems described above. During the implementation of automated systems in healthcare, **78% of employees noted improvements in compliance with regulations; 80% reported improvements in the accuracy of documentation; and 75% reported improvements in meeting deadlines.**¹ These are the same operational realities facing compliance in university research.

The literature on research governance is in agreement with this operational shift. Compliance, especially as the volume of data and the level of oversight increase, is a fundamental operational risk, not an administrative burden.²

*For compliance managers, the fundamental challenge is large-scale implementation.*²

The Breakdown of Execution: The Real Bottlenecks

Siloed systems, scattered oversight

Fragmented governance continues to be one of the most intransigent compliance issues. The silos, unclear ownership, and inconsistent standards that fragment the oversight process have been documented extensively.^{3,4} When compliance oversight is siloed across various departments, committees, and tools, organizations find it challenging to achieve consistency and reliable audit trails.

The problem is exacerbated by the phenomenon known as Big Data. The ever-increasing volume, variety, and velocity of data simply overwhelm governance systems that are based on manual interventions. Integrated controls are needed to improve data accuracy and completeness.²

✚ **The Practical Fix:** Automated governance systems fill this gap. Research suggests that automation is effective in minimizing manual errors and in achieving uniformity in data management.⁵ Compliance automation tools like Cayuse apply this model by providing an integrated system for IRB, IACUC, IBC, and COI that allows non-intrusive decentralized research activity access throughout the institution.⁶

Workflows That Slow Down the Process

Every step in manual workflows is prone to friction regardless of whether it concerns a submission, review, revision, or approval, and the workflows that integrate manual compliance lose the smoothness of every stage. Research indicates that organizations that rely on manual processes experience longer turnaround times and even higher error rates.¹

✚ **Measurable Impact:** In regulated environments, **73% of participants indicated a considerable drop in compliance-related errors** post the implementation of automation.¹ Automated processes incorporate rules within the workflow, thus enhancing standardization, audit preparedness, and documentation accuracy, and lessening the burden on administrative activities.⁵

In research settings at universities, delays that could be avoided are eliminated by electronic submissions, automated routing, and standard templates. Compliance management systems that are specifically designed to demonstrate this effect in practice are used by Cayuse customers to review processes and report a **67% decrease in review times**, an **80% reduction in the time required to make a decision**, and a **99.9% success rate for first submissions**; results that demonstrate process innovation instead of operational shortcuts.⁶

Lack of Insights and Management by Crisis

When compliance tracking is siloed, visibility for leaders goes away. Status of protocols, training compliance, and backlogs of reviews become hard to manage in real time, pushing teams to manage by crisis.

Automated compliance monitoring and reporting show that gaps in compliance can be detected early as long as there is continuous monitoring.⁵ Governance of data emphasizes the need of dashboards, documented trails, and alerts as a means to be more proactive.²

- ✚ **Restored Visibility:** Visibility is restored with unified systems. Features such as separated and unified task tracking, alerts, agendas, and compliance renewal reminders help manage audits in the proactive and near term. Compliance management becomes more proactive.⁶

Policies are Present, but Not Practically Usable

In most situations, a lack of policy is not the reason for a failed compliance attempt. The primary reason for failed compliance is the lack of uniformity in policy application, wherein some departments apply a policy while others do not. In governance, the lack of uniform application of policies results in multiple revisions, lengthy timeframes for reviews, and frustration for those conducting the reviews.³

Automation can reduce the lack of uniform policy application by incorporating policy guidelines into separate steps of a process. Research shows that having policy-based checks and documented steps that are the same is better than a system driven by policies that have no flexibility.⁵

From an operational point of view, systems that have configurable workflows, formulary dictionaries and auto-filled documents assist in the standardization of operational procedures while providing the flexibility to navigate complicated workflows, an advantage to both reviewers and investigators.⁶

Same Team, Added Pressure

As compliance is getting more and more complex, there are still insufficient resources dedicated to it. Studies show that organizations can achieve more with their governance activities by using automation, without having to add more people or incur additional costs.⁵

When it comes to regulatory environments, the more 'digital' a company is, the better the outcomes.¹ Companies that rely only on manual processes tend to experience employee burnout and make more mistakes.

- ✚ **Efficiency Gains:** Less manual processes and more automation such as routing, reminders and renewals improve efficiency. For example, with the adoption of certain technologies, *IACUC reviews at Cayuse are 200% faster*, enabling different uses of people's time more responsibly.⁶

Getting Research Requirements Right: Governance Over Paperwork

The message is clear across studies: the resonance of compliance success hinges on governance, not the documentation. Research data governance analyzes research data as a valuable resource that needs to integrate with compliance, security, and institutional frameworks.^{2,3}

Along with the Enforcement of governance, data, and documentation automation simplifies continuous compliance. documentation, data, and compliance automation simplifies continuous compliance. documentation, data, and compliance automation simplifies continuous compliance.⁵ AI boosts governance with real-time oversight and predictive risk assessment.⁴

Enterprise systems embody these frameworks by embedding training requirements, personnel certifications, and procedures into seamless workflows. Automatic certification tracking through HR and learning systems makes sure compliance is operationalized consistently across studies.⁶

- ✚ **Important Note:** Technological innovation is not sufficient on its own. Research emphasizes governance frameworks, personnel training, and the ethics of supervision.^{3,4} Complex case and exception management still rely heavily on human judgment.

Keeping High Expectations While Lessening the Load

In university research, modernizing the regulatory burden is still a work in progress. The multiple layers of overlapping requirements and redundant oversight divert time away from the work in the science and increase expense in the management.⁷ The burden, or costs to the system, are often unreimbursed and unsustainable.

Research suggests the need for less duplication of oversight and more flexible compliance models that still keep the same level of thoroughness.⁷ Centralized compliance systems capture this need by streamlining reporting, increasing transparency, and decreasing the unnecessary work.^{1,6}

Equity is a further benefit of standardization by lessening the uneven burdens from disparate compliance resources across divisions and locations.⁷

Bottom Line: Operational Results are Compliance Outcomes

There is unambiguous evidence across numerous regulated domains. Compliance failures are seldom purposeful—they are operational. The firm creation of integrated governance with automated standardized workflows improves positive outcomes in the creation and timeliness of workflows and adherence to regulation.

✚ **Final Evidence:** In **76% of cases** in healthcare administration reporting the adoption of electronic systems, there was an improvement in the consistency of the system, and in **77% of the cases** reporting the adoption of electronic systems, there was an improvement in consistency and fewer errors in documentation.¹ Data in governance research illustrates that sustained compliance at scale along with automated systems provides support for audits.²⁻⁵

For leaders in university research, the way ahead is straightforward: Pinpoint where there are manual handoffs, splintered tracking, and workflow inconsistency which create risk and solve for those with systems designed for execution, not for documentation.

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